

technology, so how can technology ruin itself? This one is more a case of the internet as a phenomenon ruining games. Again, given the sheer popularity of online games this seems counterintuitive, but you're going to have to hear us out while we complain like old people about the superiority of a time gone by.

The beginning of the mass appeal of video games started with the first popular consoles, the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES) and Atari and the likes. Even those super simple games (by modern standards) were addictive, just as many simple games like Candy Crush are today as well, and you don't consider yourself a "gamer" just because you play them.

Ever since the first FPS games came out, we entered a race to get better graphics and more processing power than every other game or GPU that came before. This is a race that exists even today for GPUs, but games don't seem to care about realism or graphics anymore, and instead want to focus on multiplayer aspects. What most games have given up on is storylines, and single player modes, because the world is much more interested in competing with one another rather than living vicariously through games as many of us used to do a mere decade ago. Of course the big budget studios still make an attempt to release single player FPS games every now and then, but the concept of downloadable content (DLC) has ruined those as well. We can thank the increase in broadband speeds for DLCs, and the much shortened storylines of the few games that still follow that format...

It's not just us nerds suffering though, as fans of sports across the globe are also complaining about the intrusiveness of technology. Football fans around the world are divided about the intrusion of VAR (Video Assistant Referee) into the game. Unlike Cricket where there is a pause at the end of each ball bowled, football was always a free flowing sport, and the faster the game is played the more exciting it becomes. While there are many who complain even about the inclusion of technology aids for

umpires in cricket such as the snick metres and the video replays, and the challenges for decisions made by the umpires... it still doesn't ruin the flow of the game as much as it can in football. The closer the decision in football, for an offside call, for example, the longer the VAR takes, which means that there is even more delay for literally negligible advantages an attacking player might have got, which is the exact opposite of how things should work in football. After all, how much of an advantage has an attacking player really gained by having one inch of a toe closer to goal than the last defender? And worse, is it worth it to stop a game for a minute or four just to identify that one inch advantage? We're sure there are lovers of many other sports who feel the same way about some of the implementation of technology aids. What's your pet peeve?

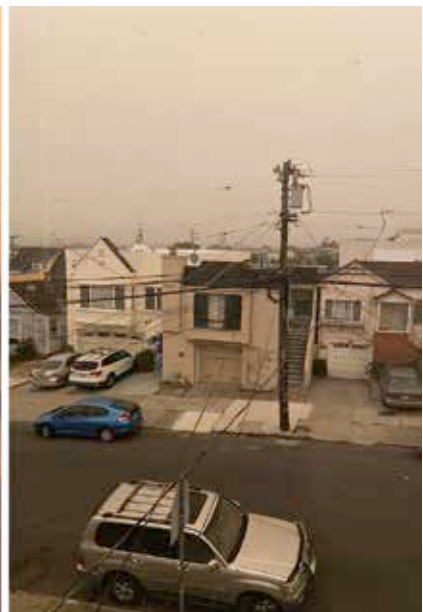
■ STILL PHOTOGRAPHY

This is a tough one, to be totally honest. Technology has given everyone a camera in their pocket, at a very affordable price, and with features far in excess of what most lay people need. In fact, thanks to technology more pictures are being clicked today than ever before, and even more will be clicked tomorrow. Still, most of those pictures are people clicking pictures of their unmentionables, or

just 300 pictures a day of their pet or baby!

Our complaint here is essentially about the software and AI driven helping hands that most smartphones provide now, so that people are just pointing and clicking without realising anything about the art of photography, or even beginning to try and understand the theory of it all. Most people (people who are not Digit readers or geeks, obviously) are pretty much only interested in filters and megapixels, which are the things that matter the least in terms of camera quality. Social media and groupthink have resulted in more people caring about whether a camera app has the ability to add floppy ears and a large tongue on to their selfies than the sensor size, ISO range, or focal lengths of a lens.

There are some positives though, because smarter AI is resulting in apps that inform a user of how to improve a shot, and many show the settings being used, so we can hope some basics get absorbed subliminally at least. Of course AI isn't without its flaws, and there have been multiple complaints about smartphone camera AI and how it ruins photos on auto mode. For example, People living in areas where there were wildfires earlier were trying to capture the ominous orange glow that dominates the sky during such events, and the



The same scene captured by a dSLR to the left and a smartphone camera to the right.

Credit: @teriarchibbles on Twitter